Technical and Business Writing

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Clear & Direct + Logical + User-centred = Good instructions

Consumer-oriented instructions

When you are drafting consumer-oriented manuals

You need to know. . .

- Who is the user?
- What do they already know?
- What can confuse them?

Instructions give commands.

No ‘should’	• ❌ The temperature sensor should be placed…
No ‘it is recommended’	• ❌ It is recommended that you slide…
No passive voice	• ❌ Sliding the sensor back is recommended…
Use imperatives	• ✓ Slide the temperature sensor back into its holder.

One action per step

If the user fails at one action, they must know exactly where they failed.

❌ Select the file and click open and adjust the size..

✓ Select the file.

✓ Click Open.

✓ Adjust the size.

Avoid wordiness and informal words

- ✗ just
- ✗ simply
- ✗ in an easy manner
- ✗ adequately

Why are these weak???

Because they are:

- Vague
- Subjective
- Unnecessary

Be specific

✗ Click the button.
✓ Click the Print button.

✗ Open the menu.
✓ Open the File menu.

Users should never guess.

Logical order (Chronology)

Can you print before opening the document?

Steps must follow logical order.

Referencing Figures

✗ as shown in the figure
✓ as shown in Figure 1

Capitalize and number figures.

Avoid these mistake.

- Writing paragraphs instead of steps
- Using passive voice
- Combining multiple actions
- Skipping steps
- Being too general
- Assuming user knowledge

Feature Vs Task oriented writing approach

Feature: Component of Software

Task: Action user performs

Feature

Setting

Core Task

Change notification preferences

Why do people open a banking app?

Transfer money

Check balance

Process payment

Examples of core tasks

Your core tasks become headings in user manual.

❌ Bad Heading Structure

- Dashboard
- Settings
- Reports

Good Heading Structure

- How to create an account
- How to add a product
- How to generate a report

Headings should be descriptive, informative,and direct.

How to identify core tasks?

What are the first 5 things a new user must do?

What actions are performed daily?

What actions are critical for successfully using the product/app?

What actions could cause confusion?

User Profile: Audience analysis

Would you write the same manual for:

First year students

Elderly user

Non-technical users

You must decide:

- Who is the user?
- What is their technical level?
- What problems do they face?

Guidelines for designing a usermanual

tell the reader where they are→tell them what to do→describe the results of their actions

- Orient the users: tell the users where they are and what they should be seeing on their screens.
- Tell them what button(s) to click on the current window and/or what text they need to type into what field(s).
- Explain with the help of graphics (screen shots).
- Tell them how to get to the next step/location and describe what they should see
- onscreen when they take that action.

Do read ‘writing instructions’ pages 1-3 from week 5 manual.